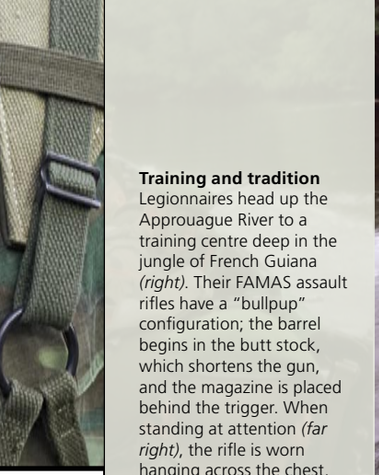






Training and tradition
Legionnaires head up the Approuague River to a training centre deep in the jungle of French Guiana *(right)*. Their FAMAS assault rifles have a "bullpup" configuration; the barrel begins in the butt stock, which shortens the gun, and the magazine is placed behind the trigger. When standing at attention *(far right)*, the rifle is worn hanging across the chest.

"YOU ARE A VOLUNTEER SERVING FRANCE WITH HONOUR AND FIDELITY. EVERY LEGIONNAIRE IS YOUR BROTHER ... REGARDLESS OF NATIONALITY, RACE, OR RELIGION. YOU WILL DEMONSTRATE THIS BY THE STRICT SOLIDARITY WHICH MUST ALWAYS UNITE MEMBERS OF THE SAME FAMILY."

FRENCH FOREIGN LEGION CODE OF HONOUR

Since the language of command is French, recruits from France or Francophile countries have the best chance of promotion.

As a force drawn from many nationalities, legionnaires have traditionally been taught loyalty to the Legion, rather than to France – hence the motto *Legio patria nostra* ("the Legion is our homeland"). Legionnaires are inculcated with the history of more than 170 years of warfare, a story in which sacrificial zeal in defeat is celebrated with even greater enthusiasm than victory. The Legion's combat reputation was founded upon decades of desert warfare against Muslim tribesmen resisting the French presence in North Africa, from Abd al-Qadir to Abd al-Krim. Becoming France's favourite expeditionary force, it fought in the Crimea in the 1850s, in Mexico in the 1860s, in Indochina in the 1880s, and in Dahomey and Madagascar in the 1890s. The Mexican expedition was the occasion for the destruction of a Legion company in a famous action at Camerone. The Legion also served with distinction in Europe, from the battles of Magenta and Solferino in Italy in 1859 to the trenches of the Western Front during World War I. In World War II, after the defeat of France in 1940, the Legion was split between allegiance to the Vichy government and the Free French movement; legionnaries briefly fought one another in Syria in 1941. Yet units of the Legion performed outstandingly against Rommel's forces at Bir Hakeim in the Western Desert in 1942 and eventually participated in the liberation of France in 1944.



Paratrooper's badge
This beret badge bears the parachute regiment's multi-winged dagger insignia.

END OF EMPIRE

Determined to hold on to its colonial empire, France certainly needed its Foreign Legion after 1945. For political reasons, the conscripts who made up the bulk of the French Army could not be thrown into the costly job of resisting anti-colonial uprisings. This task fell to French colonial forces and, above all, to the Foreign Legion. The Legion that entered this most controversial phase of its history was probably tougher than ever before or since. Its largest national contingent was from Germany, many of them, as has been mentioned, recruited directly from prisoner-of-war camps at the war's end. To call these men "battle-hardened" would be an understatement, since many had taken part in the almost unimaginable carnage and massacre of the war on Germany's Eastern Front. Another major source of new recruits were Frenchmen who had collaborated with the Nazis during the occupation of France, taking refuge in the Legion to avoid retribution. These were the sort of men who faced the communist-led Viet Minh movement in a brutal struggle for control of Indochina from 1946 to 1954. At any one time between 20,000 and 30,000 legionnaires were serving there. Faced with an elusive enemy using guerrilla tactics, they were ordered to build and defend formidable "hedgehog" strongpoints in contested territory. Since the Viet Minh



MAS 49/56
Adopted by the Legion in 1959, and chambered for the 7.5mm x 54 French round, the MAS 49/56 saw service until 1980, when it was replaced by the FAMAS assault rifle. This version has a grenade launcher sight and a night sight accessory.